

The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter



Photograph: Getty Images

Hizbullah rejected **Israel** and **Lebanon's** latest ceasefire agreement. It would mean “surrender, defeat and achieving the enemy’s goals,” the Iran-backed militant group said. Earlier, Israel’s defence minister said that “fire and ground” operations in southern Lebanon would continue. That is likely to complicate negotiations between Iran and America. For Iran a ceasefire in Lebanon is a requirement for peace talks.

Blackstone, a big American private-equity firm, is limiting withdrawals from its \$45bn private-credit fund after investors attempted to pull out \$4.5bn in the second quarter. The cap follows similar decisions by rivals like BlackRock in March, and by Partners Group, a Swiss firm, on Wednesday. Fears that [private lenders are overexposed](#) to software companies, which could be disrupted by AI, have prompted investors to retreat.

European Union member states unanimously agreed to begin talks with **Ukraine** and **Moldova** on joining the bloc. Cyprus, which holds the rotating presidency of the EU, said the decision marks a “significant milestone” in the two countries’ “European-integration path”. Hungary dropped its objections to the talks after its pro-Russian prime minister, Viktor Orban, lost an election in April.

John Bolton, Donald Trump's former national security adviser, reached a deal with federal prosecutors to plead guilty to one count of mishandling classified documents. The agreement resolves an 18-count [indictment](#) alleging he shared classified diary-like notes from his time in office with family members while preparing a memoir. He may now avoid prison, but still faces a hefty fine.

Shares in **Broadcom** plunged by more than 10% after it forecast lower-than-expected revenues from artificial-intelligence chips. The American firm said it expected revenues of \$56bn from AI chips for the year ending in October, below the average estimate of \$57.6bn. Broadcom's shares had surged in recent months, buoyed by excitement about deals it signed with [tech giants](#), including Alphabet and Meta.

Kim Jong Un, **North Korea's** leader, inspected a “newly commissioned **nuclear-material** production plant”, according to state media. South Korea's army identified it as a uranium-enrichment facility. During the visit, Mr Kim claimed the factory would help expand [his country's](#) “nuclear forces at an exponential rate”. North Korea has resisted international pressure to give up its nuclear weapons.

South Africa's government will send envoys abroad to repair relations after weeks of anti-immigrant protests in the country. Protesters say illegal migrants are straining public services and causing high unemployment. The increasingly violent protests have caused hundreds of foreigners to flee and led Malawi, Ghana and other African countries to repatriate their citizens. Mozambique claims five of its citizens were killed in the attacks; South Africa is investigating two deaths.

Figure of the day: four-fifths, the fraction of all chips that Intel and AMD supply for PCs. Find out how Nvidia is [shaking up the laptop market](#).



Photograph: Reuters

Russia's economy rumbles on

The St Petersburg International Economic Forum, Russia's annual showcase for investors, continues on Thursday. "Russia's Davos" takes place at a better moment for the Kremlin than seemed likely a few months ago. At the start of the year, a combination of falling oil prices and ultra-high interest rates led many to believe that Russia was on the verge of recession. More recently, though, firmer oil prices linked to the Iran war have lifted export revenues and eased pressure on public finances. Unemployment remains near record lows, reflecting labour shortages and resilient demand.

Growth is far slower than in the go-go years of 2023 and 2024, with officials recently cutting forecasts. [Ukrainian drone attacks](#) including on a refinery near the get-together on its opening day, limit Russia's ability to benefit from higher oil prices. But the economy remains stronger than expected after Vladimir Putin's invasion of Ukraine. Having confounded predictions of its demise throughout the war, it has done so once again.



Photograph: Reuters

High season for SCOTUS

On Thursday America's Supreme Court will rule on one or more of the 26 cases that need concluding before holidays in July. Its justices have hardly been slacking: recent decisions have facilitated making last minute changes to congressional maps, boosting Republicans' chances of preserving their slim majority in the House of Representatives.

Not all of their rulings have favoured Donald Trump, however; the court upended his signature tariff policy in February. It is also expected to strike down both his bid to withhold automatic citizenship from [babies born to undocumented immigrants or temporary visa-holders](#), and his attempt to sack a Federal Reserve governor on flimsy grounds.

But [Mr Trump stands to triumph](#) in his push for greater executive power. The court will probably scuttle a 91-year-old precedent preventing the president from removing the heads of most administrative agencies. The justices will then wade further into the culture wars. Judgments are due on cases involving gun rights for (occasional) drug users, transgender women in sports and postal ballots.



Photograph: Alamy

Reform UK pushes for a “George Floyd” moment

A murder in Britain has become a political minefield. Henry Nowak was bleeding from multiple knife wounds when police clapped him in handcuffs, hesitating to administer first aid for about a minute. The murderer, Vickrum Digwa, a Sikh, had falsely claimed the white teenager had racially abused him.

Mr Nowak died shortly afterwards, on December 3rd. But the harrowing video footage of his last moments only emerged this week. Nigel Farage and his Reform UK colleagues immediately [seized on it](#) to argue that Britain is subject to “two-tier policing”, which discriminates against white people. Mr Farage, whose populist right-wing party is leading in opinion polls, broadcast an “emergency address” declaring that “white lives matter too”.

Public anger spilled over into the streets of Southampton, where the killing occurred. Similar cases, such as the murder of three young girls at a dance class in 2024, have sparked extended episodes of violence. Rabble-rousing from Mr Farage, who has refused to disavow the protests, could easily encourage another one.

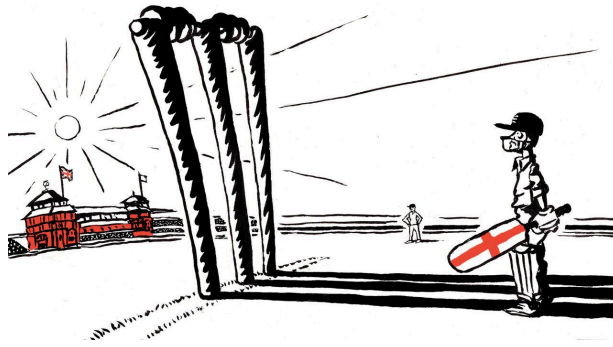


Illustration: David Simonds

“Bazball” returns to cricket

In 2022 the England Cricket Board appointed a pugnacious New Zealander, Brendon McCullum, as coach of its international men’s team. Mr McCullum instituted an ultra-aggressive approach to five-day Test cricket that the media dubbed “Bazball”. His tactics initially stumped opponents, but a humbling in Australia last winter, during which the team was pilloried for poor preparation, worse cricket and excessive drinking, prompted a rethink. The ECB retained Mr McCullum, but he has a brief to encourage more responsible cricket.

The second age of Bazball begins on Thursday at Lord’s, the “Home of Cricket” in London, with a three-match series against New Zealand. Two mainstays of the first era, Zak Crawley and Ollie Pope, are gone. Most intriguingly, England have recalled Ollie Robinson, a bowler who made a brilliant start to his Test career in 2021 but was dropped because of concerns about his commitment. England’s frustrated fans hope that Bazball 2.0 proves to be both sensible and invincible.



Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Daily quiz

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 BST on Friday to [\[email protected\]](#). We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Thursday: The recovery programme at Alcoholics Anonymous consists of 12 what?

Wednesday: Which highly common animal group is believed to have descended from dinosaurs?

Failure is not fatal but failure to change might be.

John Wooden